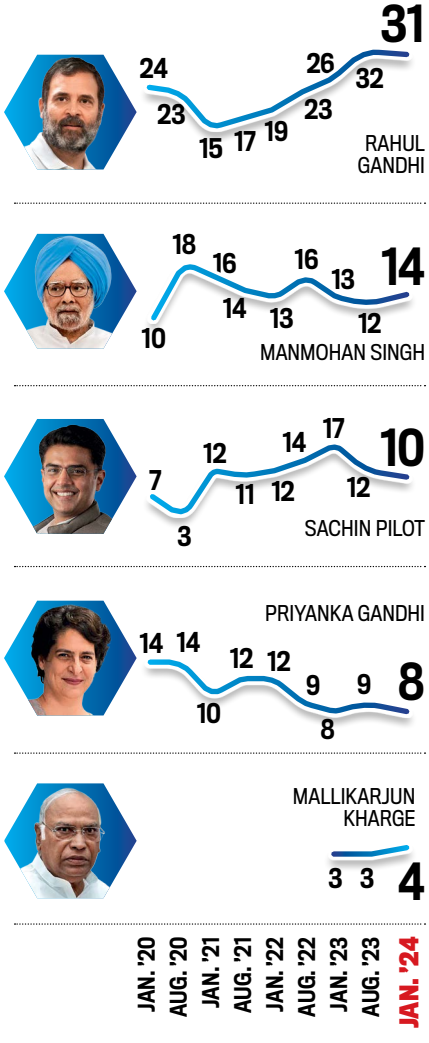
the template for the Opposition's social justice pitch around the caste census. Ever since Nitish trained his focus on social justice—with the caste survey in Bihar and the release of the findings—Rahul had sought to make it a national agenda by raising the pitch for rights proportionate to the share of population. The demand for a caste census was aimed at denting the BJP's OBC vote bank, which had become its mainstay in the past two Lok Sabha and several assembly polls. The share of the OBC population in India is believed to be more than the 52 per cent the Mandal Commission estimated in the 1980s, and hence deserving of a larger share in the reservation pie than the existing 27 per cent. The findings of Bihar's caste survey corroborate this to an extent.

But though Nitish may have changed his stripes, the caste census narrative retains strong resonance among voters. Nearly 50 per cent of the respondents say caste census is not dead as an issue even after Nitish's exit from I.N.D.I.A. That there is a strong public opinion in favour has been recognised even by the BJP, which has till now stayed non-committal on conducting such an exercise at the national level, even though it seldom misses an opportunity to emphasise that the party supported the decision to conduct a caste survey in Bihar in the assembly. In fact, the Centre's move to honour former Bihar CM and OBC icon Karpoori Thakur with the Bharat Ratna, just days before Nitish's return to the NDA fold, was aimed at countering the caste narrative of I.N.D.I.A. On February 5, in a scathing attack on the Opposition parties, PM Modi once again reiterated his OBC identity, saying his detractors failed to see how high an OBC had risen under BJP rule.

In his speech, the prime minister also talked about the 'elevation' of the Opposition parties—to the visitor's

Q. Which Congress leader is best suited to revive the party?

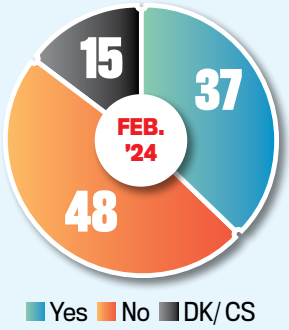


All figures in % and rounded off

Rahul is the Congress's undisputed leader; the lack of credible leadership otherwise is telling

42
PER CENT
CONSIDER THE CONGRESS'S PERFORMANCE GOOD OR OUTSTANDING AS AN OPPOSITION PARTY

Q. Will you weigh in Rahul Gandhi's Bharat Jodo Nyay Yatra while casting your vote in the 2024 Lok Sabha election?



The BJNY seems of no consequence to almost half the electorate

Q. What do you think of Rahul Gandhi's Bharat Jodo Nyay Yatra?

It's a great political move to raise awareness about important issues	25
It will help Congress gain public attention	20
It will make no difference to Congress performance in Lok Sabha polls	32
It's an image management drill for Rahul Gandhi	11

The sea of people is a positive but with the party organisation weak, it does little for the Congress

All figures in % and rounded off; rest: DK/CS